

Australia Daily Brief

Wednesday, October 7, 2026

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RE: Trump unveils AUKUS submarine shipyard in Baltimore · PNG pledges US\$5.5m to Tuvalu · High Court puts overseas coal emissions in planning · Labor defends \$20m Pre-COP bill · ADF grounds Supacat fleet

ASX 200

8,728

-0.70%

AUD/USD

0.6971

+0.36%

NZX 50

13,684

-1.09%

NZD/USD

0.5608

-0.48%

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• TODAY AT A GLANCE

- 1 Papua New Guinea pledged US\$5.5 million over five years for Tuvalu's coastal reclamation, announced by Prime Minister James Marape at Pre-COP31 in Funafuti.
- 2 Trump travelled to Baltimore to announce a multibillion-dollar US shipyard investment that administration officials said would lift the lagging Virginia-class production rate underpinning AUKUS.
- 3 Australia's High Court ruled by majority that planning authorities must consider overseas emissions when approving fossil fuel projects, a decision Bloomberg frames as a test for a \$49 billion coal export sector.

• TOP STORIES

AUKUS

Trump announces multibillion-dollar shipyard for AUKUS submarines

Donald Trump travelled to Baltimore to announce a new United States shipyard costing billions of dollars, which administration officials said would bolster the lagging production rate of Virginia-class vessels. Production tempo is the central variable in the AUKUS submarine pipeline: Australia's acquisition pathway depends on American yards building faster than they currently do. The announcement carried no figure for Australian participation and no revised delivery schedule.

per SMH World: "US to spend billions on new shipyard for AUKUS submarines"

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

PNG commits US\$5.5 million to Tuvalu coastal reclamation

Papua New Guinea will give Tuvalu about *US\$5.5 million* (K25 million) over five years for coastal reclamation, Prime Minister **James Marape** said at Pre-COP31 in Funafuti, with funds allocated from each annual budget. "It would buy them two or three more generations of life," Marape said, urging others to "rally behind them" rather than attend COPs "with no serious commitments." Tuvaluan Prime Minister **Feleti Teo** said the money would secure the country's most exposed coastline. Tuvalu's atolls total 26 square kilometres.

per RNZ Pacific: "Let's rally behind them": PNG commits to help Tuvalu at Pre-COP climate meet"

TRADE-ECONOMY

High Court puts overseas coal emissions into Australian planning law

A majority of the High Court found planning authorities must consider how emissions burned overseas are managed when approving fossil fuel projects in Australia. The ruling favours a Hunter Valley residents group that halted the Mount Pleasant coal mine expansion in the New South Wales Court of Appeal last year. Bloomberg reports the decision tests a *\$49 billion* coal export sector; New South Wales mines will now have to account for downstream emissions at approval stage.

per Bloomberg: "Climate Ruling Deals Blow to Australia's \$49 Billion Coal Export Sector" · also The Australian

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

Labor defends \$20 million bill for Pacific climate diplomacy

Pre-COP31 in Fiji and Tuvalu was designed to showcase Australian leadership before COP31, but major world leaders skipped it, leaving **Anthony Albanese's** government defending a *\$20 million* cost, SMH reports. The domestic argument lands while Canberra weighs several fossil fuel project expansions at home. Australia's Pacific climate credentials are the hinge of its COP31 partnership with the region.

per SMH Federal Politics: "Why Albanese will pay a domestic price for his Pacific diplomacy"

• OVERNIGHT

AU-DEFENSE

[ADF grounds Supacat troop carrier after fatal Northern Territory rollover](#) · ABC News

The Australian Defence Force paused use of the Supacat HMT troop carrier involved in Monday's rollover at the Mount Bunday Training Area that killed Corporal **Brendan Hannam**, 28, and injured five others. Chief of Army Lieutenant General **Susan Coyle** confirmed the vehicle type in Perth and said Hannam was a passenger, not the driver. The vehicle is used by 1st Brigade and special forces units. Two injured soldiers remain in Royal Darwin Hospital.

AU-POLITICS

[Business and universities turn on Coalition migration cuts](#) · SMH Federal Politics

Angus Taylor dismissed critics as "vested interests" after a property group called his migration policy a flat tyre, SMH reports, with one Labor figure saying the plan read as if written by AI. The Coalition would halve net migration to 100,000 for two years through cuts to graduate, refugee, and bridging visas, then tie

intake to housing completions. Commonwealth Bank chief executive **Matt Comyn** called migration an "economic tailwind"; International Education Association chief **Phil Honeywood** said the Coalition was "trying to keep up with One Nation."

US-AUSTRALIA [Washington issues sanctions warning over Israel trade measures](#) · The Australian

The United States warned of sanctions over Israel trade bans and used "termites" language on antisemitism accountability, The Australian reports, in coverage directed at both Europe and Australia. Separately, a US legal expert told the Bondi attack inquiry that antisemitism behaves like a "termite" infestation.

US-AUSTRALIA [Hockey says corruption is flourishing in Washington](#) · ABC News

Former Australian ambassador to the United States **Joe Hockey** told ABC's 7.30 there was "no doubt" corruption had been allowed to flourish in Washington, contrasting it with what he called Australia's "essentially corruption-free government." He said the problem had become worse and "more apparent" over the past two years and cited congressional share trading alongside administration dealings. Hockey also described Trump as possibly the most influential president of the past century while saying he had diminished American standing.

AU-POLITICS [Privacy commissioner opens formal probe into Chinese smart-glasses firm](#) · ABC News

Privacy commissioner **Carly Kind** launched a formal investigation into Shenzhen Qingcheng, the Chinese software company behind cheap smart glasses sold through Kmart, Big W Marketplace, and Amazon. An ABC investigation found more than a dozen serious security flaws in the HeyCyan app, exposing email addresses, dates of birth, images, and video. Attorney-General **Michelle Rowland** asked the regulator in August to prioritise the issue amid calls for an import ban.

US-AUSTRALIA [O'Brien puts a US artificial intelligence deal first in line](#) · The Australian

Shadow Minister for Foreign Affairs **Ted O'Brien** said an artificial intelligence agreement with the United States would be the Coalition's "first priority," The Australian reports. The positioning lands while a joint select committee examines AI regulation in Canberra and the government prepares national AI standards.

AU-POLITICS [Accused hijack pilot called his Australian years his religious "golden years"](#) · SMH

Unearthed posts by alleged terrorist **Hammam al-Hammami** describe his time in Australia as the "golden years" of his religious devotion, SMH reports, alongside his views on religion and relationships. The material feeds the counterterrorism examination of the accused flydubai co-pilot's Australian links.

• **STAT OF THE DAY**

US\$5.5 million

PNG pledge to Tuvalu coastal reclamation over five years

Marape committed the funds from successive PNG budgets at Pre-COP31, the first Pacific-to-Pacific adaptation pledge of the meeting.

RNZ Pacific

• **PACIFIC WIRE**

REGIONAL · ABC PACIFIC

Leaders endorse Taku Pakasoa Declaration at Pre-COP31

Leaders returning to Fiji from Tuvalu effectively endorsed the Taku Pakasoa Declaration, calling on the world to unite with frontline states. ABC climate reporter **Romy Stephens** said the text reiterates that "every fraction of a degree of warming accelerates the impacts of climate change." **Anthony Albanese** and Energy Minister **Chris Bowen** declined to wear the hand-made floral garlands offered to leaders at the traditional welcome in Tuvalu.

FIJI · AFP

Fiji minister calls climate finance access "personal"

A Fijian minister pressed for better climate finance at the pre-COP talks, telling AFP the issue is "personal" for Pacific states. Access and speed of disbursement, rather than new pledges, have dominated the Fiji leg of the meeting.

FIJI · ABC PACIFIC

Civil society says Fiji's December 9 referendum cannot proceed

Civil society groups in Fiji say the prime minister's nominated referendum day of December 9 cannot happen because the Constitution Amendment Bill has yet to pass its third reading in parliament. The bill governs the threshold for amending Fiji's constitution, and the timetable now depends on the parliamentary calendar.

COOK ISLANDS · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Mark Brown stays on as Cook Islands prime minister

Mark Brown will continue as Prime Minister of the Cook Islands after the 2026 general election, with the Cook Islands Party returned to government, Islands Business reports.

TONGA · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Tongan growers welcome regional kava declaration

Tonga's kava growers and exporters welcomed a regional declaration by Pacific leaders on the plant, which Islands Business describes as having become a major export earner. The declaration gives producers a regional reference point as external markets tighten import rules.

KIRIBATI · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Kava becomes Kiribati's "liquid gold" without a local tradition

Unlike Fiji, Vanuatu, Tonga, and several other Pacific societies, Kiribati has no ancient tradition of cultivating or drinking kava, Islands Business reports, yet the drink has become a significant part of commerce and community life there. Imported demand links Kiribati to the same regional supply chain now covered by the leaders' kava declaration.

SOLOMON ISLANDS · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Solomon Islands engineer breaks into male-dominated construction sector

Civil engineer **Rowena Toito'ona** is among the women entering Pacific industries long treated as men's territory, Islands Business reports, in a Solomon Islands construction sector central to donor-funded infrastructure delivery.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · ABC PACIFIC

PNG activist turns sorcery accusation into women's rights work

Monica Paulus, accused of sorcery in Papua New Guinea, became a human rights activist working with women facing the same accusations, ABC Pacific reports. Sorcery accusation related violence remains a persistent law and order problem for PNG authorities and their Australian partners.

• NEW ZEALAND

NZ-POLITICS · ABC RADIO NATIONAL BREAKFAST

ABC previews New Zealand's November election

ABC Radio National Breakfast ran a segment, "What to know about New Zealand's upcoming election," ahead of the Saturday 7 November 2026 poll, with advance voting opening 26 October. **Christopher Luxon's** National, ACT, and NZ First coalition is seeking a second term.

• CANBERRA POLITICS

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

Firmus pulls out of Canberra's AI inquiry at the eleventh hour

Firmus withdrew from the federal artificial intelligence inquiry at the last minute, The Australian reports, after OpenAI and Commonwealth Bank executives appeared before the committee this week. The company is pursuing a large Australian listing while sovereignty of AI infrastructure is under parliamentary scrutiny.

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

Teal challenger raises \$250,000 to take on Liberal leader

A teal challenger has assembled a \$250,000 war chest to contest the seat of Liberal leader **Jess Wilson**, The Australian reports, ahead of Victoria's November state election.

• BUSINESS AND ECONOMY

TRADE-ECONOMY · THE AUSTRALIAN

Deloitte calls time on Australia's golden era

Deloitte has declared the end of Australia's economic golden era, The Australian reports, under the headline "Good while it lasted." The assessment lands as the Coalition's migration cuts and rate pressure dominate the growth debate.

TRADE-ECONOMY · SMH FEDERAL POLITICS

Home completions rise but stay well short of federal targets

Housing completions picked up over the quarter but remain well short of government targets, SMH reports, with rising construction costs and interest rate pressure set to stall momentum. The Coalition proposes tying migration intake to the pace of completions.

TRADE-ECONOMY · THE AUSTRALIAN

Housing program shortfall to cost states \$11 billion in lost tax

Labor's housing program shortfall will cost the states \$11 billion in forgone tax revenue, The Australian reports, compounding state budget pressure already flagged over falling property values.

TRADE-ECONOMY · ABC NEWS

Chinese travellers make Australia a Golden Week destination

Australia ranked among the most sought-after destinations during China's October 1 to 7 national holiday, according to booking platform Trip.com, which reported travellers taking "longer and further trips beyond the region." The Mid-Autumn Festival holiday extended the break to 13 days. A Melbourne travel agent said Chinese visitors increasingly prefer small-group or self-drive trips over large tours.

• PRIMARY DOCUMENTS

COMMUNIQUE · VIVEKANANDA INTERNATIONAL FOUNDATION

Assessment of the 2026 Pacific Islands Forum meeting and the limits of consensus

A review of the 2026 Pacific Islands Forum Leaders Meeting examines Pacific-led regionalism and the constraints consensus decision-making places on it. The question matters for members weighing collective positions on external security partners.

• UPCOMING

OCT
26

Advance voting opens for the New Zealand general election

Early ballots begin shaping the coalition arithmetic that will decide who holds foreign affairs and defence in Wellington.

NOV
7

New Zealand general election

Decides whether the National, ACT, and NZ First coalition continues, and with it the current settings on defence spending and Pacific policy.

NOV
2026

COP31 United Nations climate conference

Pacific states will carry the Taku Pakasoa Declaration into the negotiation that follows this week's Pre-COP in Fiji and Tuvalu.

DEC
2026

Fiji constitutional referendum, nominated for December 9

Civil society says the date cannot stand until the Constitution Amendment Bill passes its third reading, putting Fiji's amendment timetable in doubt.

• THE WIRE

AU-DEFENSE

ASPI STRATEGIST

As allies' capabilities grow, they need to work with US on nuclear signalling

The next Indo-Pacific deterrence problem may be a shortage of coordination rather than capability, the piece argues, as Australia, Japan, and South Korea field long-range strike and missile defence systems that interact with American nuclear signalling.

AUSTRALIAN DEFENCE MAGAZINE

Shield AI and Innovaero to collaborate on strike capability

Shield AI and Western Australian manufacturer Innovaero will collaborate on a strike capability, Australian Defence Magazine reports, announced around the Land Forces exhibition.

AUSTRALIAN DEFENCE MAGAZINE

Land Forces 2026 opens in Perth

Australian Defence Magazine filed day one coverage from Land Forces 2026, the exhibition that drew hundreds of protesters in Perth this week.

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

ASPI STRATEGIST

Australia's Middle East priority should be working with those that can counter Iran

Australia needs a more active and hardheaded Middle East approach to deal with conflicts stemming from or worsened by the October 7 attacks, the piece argues, prioritising partners able to counter Iran.

LOWY INTERPRETER

A new drug superhighway: Australia's meth now runs via southern Africa

Methamphetamine bound for Australia increasingly routes through southern Africa, the Interpreter reports, concluding that "policing the Pacific harder won't close this gap."

AU-POLITICS

WASHINGTON POST

Former Australian Catholic bishop sentenced for abusing Indigenous men

A former Australian Catholic bishop was sentenced for abusing Indigenous men, the Washington Post reports from the Broome case.

TRADE-ECONOMY

SMH

Australia unveils first moon rover prototype ahead of 2030 mission

Australia unveiled its first lunar rover prototype at the Queensland University of Technology, SMH reports, built for a space agency mission targeting 2030.

CSIS Australia Chair

AUSTRALIA DAILY BRIEF

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